oir with incident. Hers is a fabulous life, as in a life that seems more mythical, more magical than real. Roy's sheer indomitability, her ability to turn almost every adversity into fairy tale triumph, gives *Mother Mary Comes to Me* a picaresque quality. She doesn't dwell, doesn't wallow in grief or self-pity—she just keeps bouncing over obstacles.

In the end, *Mother Mary Comes to Me* is a paean to freedom, to independence. Roy took the astonishing Booker-winning success of *The God of Small Things* as a sign that she could now face the world on her own terms. Her greatest strength as a writer—as a human being—is her radical empathy. It's a necessary antidote to the times. "We've become," Roy says, "for the most part, a hateful people who have narrowed their understanding of everything to a pinpoint." The lesson we can learn from the Roys, mother and daughter, is to open our minds and our hearts to others. ■

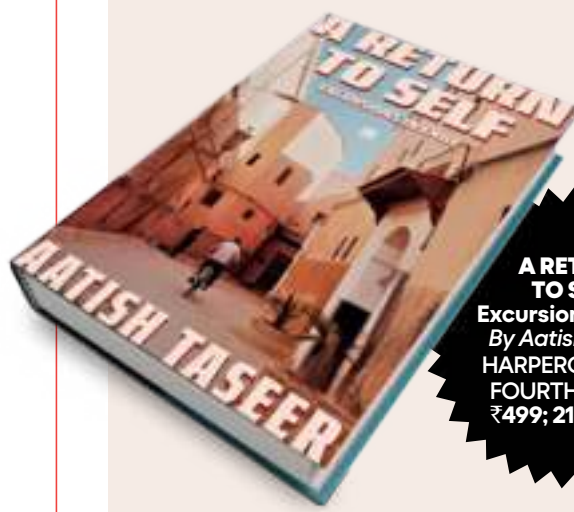
—Shougat Dasgupta

BOOKS ▼

A BOUQUET OF MARVELS

AATISH TASEER's new collection of essays is part memoir and part travelogue

Exiled from India in 2019, Aatish Taseer sets out to write a series of wonderfully evocative travel essays. Commissioned by *T: The New York Times Style* magazine, they were clearly also a form of therapy, helping the author process his sense of outrage and loss.



A RETURN TO SELF
Excursions in Exile
By Aatish Taseer
HARPERCOLLINS/ FOURTH ESTATE
₹499; 216 pages

The first of these journeys is to Istanbul, where he reconnects with memories of when he travelled as a straight man with a girlfriend while struggling to conceal his attraction to beautiful young men. The second journey begins with being introduced, as a teenager in his mother's home in New Delhi, to an extraordinary scent called oudh. The description is so intense, so extreme, it made my own nose ache with longing.

The third journey is a mesmerising trip to Uzbekistan. Seeing beyond the drab Soviet-era buildings, he conjures the days of Genghis Khan, when horse-borne warriors thundered westward across Central Asia, bearing death and silk. Then to Morocco where he confronts the mind-altering vastness of the great Sahara. In Spain, he listens for echoes of the five and a half centuries of Muslim rule which ended in 1248. In Mexico, he traces the arc of history through grains of rice and corn. In Sri Lanka, he's seduced by the divine purity of the lotus.

In the final and longest essay, he visits Bolivia, Mongolia and Iraq. He goes as a pilgrim, hoping to witness, and thereby understand, ecstatic expressions of faith. In Bolivia, it is the adoration of the Virgin of the Catholics merging with Pachamama, Earth Goddess of the Andes. In Mongolia, it's energy vortices paired with Russian vodka, at the gateway to the mystical region of Shambhala at the heart of Asia. In Iraq, in Najaf, a medieval spectacle is brought to life annually, as men and boys re-enact the central trauma of their Shia faith by cutting open their own scalps with knives. Ringing them are observers holding up lighted cellphones to record the ordeal.

The juxtapositions of then and now, bristling with dates and historical arcana, are occasionally overwrought. Some of Taseer's yearning for India comes across as precious. But the author's personal history certainly earns him the right to a sharpened awareness of irony. Born in the UK, he grew up in India, the love-child of Tavleen Singh, high-profile journalist and a Sikh, and Salman Taseer, a Pakistani Muslim former governor of Punjab, who was assassinated in 2011.

As a young man, the author was keenly conscious of the prejudices of traditional society towards homosexuality. He acknowledges the debt he owes to the gay movement and the writings of authors such as James Baldwin, which helped him come out. Now in his forties, he lives in New York with his husband. ■

—Manjula Padmanabhan